

Giant sequoia

The tallest living thing on Earth, the giant sequoia tree is as high as a 26-story building, and wider than the average city street. Found only in western California, these incredible trees can live for thousands of years. Even after death, they continue to support life.

New life

The life of the giant sequoia springs from its cones. Pollen from the male cones is blown on the wind to fertilize eggs in the female cones, producing seeds.

Bursting out

Seeds spread when the cones split open. This might be thanks to a hungry squirrel feeding on the cones. However, more often it is due to the cones drying out from the heat from a forest fire, causing them to split.

Young or old?

For the first 250 years, the tree is still considered to be young! In these early years, branches grow from near the base of the trunk as well as from the top. Its leaves are evergreen—they stay on the tree all year round.

Tender plant

The seed grows into a young plant called a seedling. The tree starts to produce cones when it is 10 years old and continues producing them into old age.

See also

Read more about seeds and pollination in the coconut tree (56–57) and the oak tree (62–63).

20 years old

100 years old

200 years old